But seeing the shavings while turning raised my spirits and eased the way to recovery. Five months – and 30 radiotherapy sessions – later I completed the treatment. Some 15 years on, I am in good health and still making shavings.

But back to that lathe. After a couple of years, its shortcomings were appearing, so I bit the bullet and purchased an Axminster M950 with mechanical variable speed. Attendance at hands-on evenings and a few shows led to my next purchase, the smaller Axminster M330. Both are still in use today and do everything I ask of them. Yes, I look longingly at modern electronic variable-speed lathes but then the question arises: how would I re-arrange the workshop to shoehorn one in?

What and who are the greatest influences in your work?

Visiting demonstrators who took the trouble to explain the 'hows' and 'whys' of turning and answer some basic questions. Also, for their encouragement and help, Charlie Day, the first Chairman of Chelmer Valley, who is sadly no longer with us, and Gabor Lacko

Which music and books are you into?

My taste in music is eclectic and can be affected by mood, occasion or even the weather. I have just finished reading *Singapore – A Pictorial History 1819–2000* by Gretchen Liu, which my daughter brought home for me after a recent holiday on the island

What is your silliest mistake?

Buying a lathe on impulse. Next, thinking I was competent enough to judge the depth to the bottom of an early bowl without measuring it. Yes, I went through the bottom. Lesson learnt and I have measured ever since

What has been your greatest challenge?

My first demonstration for club members. It would have been easier if I hadn't known them

Name one thing on your turning 'to do' list?

At 78, I have done most things, so my 'to do' lists are not very long and are usually trumped by those of a higher authority – my wife. The priority is still to enjoy my turning

What is the one piece of equipment or tool you would not be without and why?

It has to be the small round skew chisel that I first saw demonstrated by Gary Rance. In fact, I bought one from him that day for the grand sum of £13. Like all new tools it took a lot of practice to conquer it, even now I'm nowhere near as proficient as Gary

What is your favourite type of turning?

Anything associated with making clocks

Contact: John Austin
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Can you tell us about any of your recent projects?

About 10 years ago I bought enough ash (*Fraxinus excelsior*) to make two American platform rocking chairs to a design by Ray Jones. The ash 'matured' in my store until recently when I could no longer find excuses for not starting the chairs. Some 80 spindles later, a dry-run assembly led to a design change. The spindle that connects the seat assembly to the base was changed to a square section. The assembly was too big for my workshop, but my very understanding wife allowed me to use the dining table – covered, I hasten to add. The upholstery was also a joint effort with my wife and her sewing machine. The finished chairs have since gained an optional extra in the form of a head rest cushion

Some of the spindles used in my American chairs

My finished rocking chairs in ash, without their optional head-rest cushions

I sometimes slot a vice into the lathe bed

The original handle from my Gary Rance skew chisel

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